

Meal planning changed my buying, but it was meal *prepping* that changed my cooking habits. I (Jen) had the planning part down, but the execution was poor. When I started prepping, I filled in the gaps that meal planning just wasn't cutting. Now, when I say meal prep, I don't mean glass containers lined up on a kitchen island with a week's worth of meals perfectly portioned and positioned or mason jar salads that have always seemed impractical. I mean ingredients. Take shredded chicken, for example. I love it in soups, tacos, salads, beans and rice, and more. But the extra effort it takes to shred it with forks is a deal breaker for me. I'd rather order takeout. So, I started buying big bags of frozen chicken, cooking it, shredding it with my stand mixer, and freezing it in individual containers. Before it took me almost five minutes to hand-shred a pound of chicken; now I can do five pounds in less than thirty seconds. And cooking time is down for all my recipes because the chicken is precooked. Shredded chicken was a barrier to following through with my meal plan, and since I didn't want to eliminate it, I got creative and took the barrier away. Another barrier for me was chopping onions. Who doesn't hate chopping onions? So instead of eliminating them, because that would eliminate *a lot* of recipes, I prepped them. Now I buy a bag of onions, chop all of them in my \$20 Ninja Express Chop, and freeze in individual containers. Whenever a recipe calls for an onion, I just grab a bag and drop it into the pan, no defrosting required. These are just my examples. Over time you'll identify what your barriers are and get creative with how you get past them.

When you're trying to lower your food spending, remember that a few of the right decisions here can free you from so many other decisions later. And even small steps in the right direction make big impacts. If your goal is to lower your spending this year and you had to choose between lowering your monthly food spending by 10 percent or your clothing spending by 50 percent, which would you choose? Probably 10 percent on food, right? According to the Bureau of Labor Statistics, they both equal around \$1,000 annually. So, there's no need to try to massively overhaul your food budget. Just focus on making small changes in the right direction.